The scientist who asked for the hold got back in thirty minutes to report that he is ready for the launch. And I resumed the countdown. At T-5 (T minus five) minutes, I instructed all heads to go back to internal mode, meaning that the lift-off is imminent. Everyone confirmed with 'roger', but Calla fell silent now. Since he was sitting next to me, I asked why he hasn't said 'roger'.

As if waking up from a dream, Calla asked what my instruction was.

'To go to internal power,' I replied.

'You mean we were supposed to go to external power sometime earlier?'

Now it sank in: Calla's transponder, which had to transmit data, was drawing power from the internal battery, draining it all along. Thirty minutes on internal power means Calla's transponder was dead before the rocket was launched. Time was now running out and technically I could not allow lift-off without a 'roger' from all systems heads which included Calla. I stared hard at him and Calla said 'roger'. Both of us knew the transponder would not work, which meant the probe data will never reach us. Another death foretold. The countdown proceeded and the rocket took off. Everything worked perfectly: The nose cone ejected at 63 km, the probe might have gathered data about electron density in the atmosphere. But there was no signal from the transponder. Everything plunged into the Arabian Sea. Calla kept silent. So did I.

And that remained our secret for many years till I had to tell ISRO chairman U R Rao in a different context. Why I told Rao about it is another tale—that shows not just we the Indian toddlers in space, but even the French masters of rocketry can fail because of callousness.

The French blooper came five years later, in 1972, when they launched the three-stage Diamant-BP4. I was in Paris for the launch, as part of an ISRO-CNES programme. The project director was a man called Roussel. The French, by then precision launchers of rockets, usually have a grand lunch or dinner for every launch, and it is joked that many scientists gather in Paris while the rocket takes off from Hammaguir, Algeria, more for the lavish spread of food than the launch itself.